

THE FIRST CLIENT

A Simple Way to Land Your Very First Paying Client

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Introduction

The Hardest Client You Will Ever Get

Almost every piece of freelancing advice out there is written for people who already have clients, and are trying to get more of them, raise their prices, or build a bigger business. Very little of it is written for the much harder, much lonelier problem that comes before any of that, getting the very first one.

The first client is different from every client after it. There is no portfolio yet, no testimonials, no results to point to, only the belief that you can actually do the thing you are offering, and the hope that someone else will believe it too.

This book is entirely about that narrow, difficult stretch, from having a skill nobody has paid you for yet, to having proof that someone was willing to pay for it. Everything after that point gets meaningfully easier, but almost nothing about it is covered properly anywhere else.

If you already have some clients, most of this will feel familiar, but if you are still stuck at zero, this is written specifically for you, and specifically for how strange and quiet that particular stage of the process actually feels.

Chapter 1

Why the First Client Feels Impossible

The first client feels impossible for a very simple reason, everyone wants to hire someone with experience, but you cannot get experience without someone hiring you first. This loop traps far more capable people than it should.

On top of that, the fear at this stage is rarely about skill, it is about being seen trying and possibly failing publicly, in a way that feels far more exposed than quietly practising alone ever did.

It helps to notice that almost everyone currently working successfully in your field once stood exactly where you are standing now, with no clients, no proof, and the same quiet doubt about whether anyone would actually pay them.

The goal of this chapter is not to remove that fear entirely, it rarely disappears completely, but to recognise it as a normal part of this specific stage, rather than a sign that something is wrong with you or your skill.

Every single person with a long client list once had a list of zero. The gap between those two states is smaller, and far more crossable, than it currently feels.

Chapter 2

Getting Painfully Specific About Who You Help

A common mistake at this stage is trying to appeal to everyone, offering broad, general help to avoid narrowing the audience too soon. In practice, this usually makes it harder, not easier, to find that first client.

A specific offer is far easier to say yes to than a vague one. Compare, I help small businesses with their online presence, to, I build simple, clean websites for hair salons that want more bookings. The second is instantly clearer about who it is for and what it actually does.

Choosing a specific starting focus does not permanently lock you into that lane forever. It simply gives you a clear, sharp entry point, one that is far easier to describe, remember, and refer to someone else.

If you are unsure where to start, think about who you already understand well, through past work, personal experience, or simple curiosity, and consider starting there, since that understanding becomes a real advantage in how you speak to them.

Specific and small beats broad and vague, especially at the very beginning, when clarity matters more than reach.

Chapter 3

Proof Before Portfolio

Without any paid work yet, it can feel like there is nothing to show anyone. In reality, proof does not have to come from paid work, it simply has to come from somewhere real.

Consider doing one piece of real, complete work before you have a client for it, a sample website for a fictional business in your chosen niche, a redesigned version of an existing company's flyer, purely as a demonstration piece.

This single piece of proof does more for your credibility than any amount of describing your skills in words, because it lets someone see the actual quality of your work before they have to risk any money finding out.

It does not need to be elaborate. One genuinely good example, clearly labelled as a sample or practice project, is far more convincing than a long list of skills with nothing visible behind them.

This is often the single highest leverage hour you can spend before approaching your first potential client.

Chapter 4

Where Your First Client Is Actually Hiding

Many people searching for their first client look toward strangers online first, when the far more likely source is much closer, people who already know and trust them in some other context.

Think through people you already have some relationship with, family friends who run a small business, former colleagues, people in local community groups. These connections carry existing trust that a cold stranger simply does not.

Local business owners are often an especially good starting point, since many genuinely need the exact kind of help you may be offering, and rarely have the time or knowledge to find it themselves without someone approaching them directly.

Online communities built around your specific niche, rather than broad general platforms, tend to produce far better first opportunities too, since the people there already care about the exact problem you solve.

Your first client is rarely a stranger discovered through luck. They are usually someone already one or two steps away from you, waiting for a clear, specific offer to arrive.

Chapter 5

Reaching Out Without Sounding Desperate

The fear of sounding desperate often causes people to write vague, overly polite messages that say almost nothing concrete, which paradoxically makes them harder to respond to, not easier.

A clear, short message tends to work far better than a long, apologetic one. State plainly who you are, what you noticed about their situation, and what specific help you are offering, without excessive hedging.

For example, I noticed your salon does not currently have an online booking option, I build simple booking friendly websites for small salons, would you be open to a short call about it, is direct, specific, and easy to respond to.

Avoid over explaining your lack of experience upfront. Let the specific, useful offer speak for itself, rather than leading with a list of reasons someone might hesitate to work with you.

Confidence here is not about pretending to have more experience than you do, it is about being clear and useful enough that experience becomes a smaller part of the decision.

Chapter 6

Pricing Your First Piece of Work

Pricing the very first project is uniquely difficult, because there is no track record yet to justify a number, and both sides know it.

A reasonable approach is to price slightly below your eventual target rate, enough to make the first yes easier to reach, without pricing so low that the work feels worthless to either of you.

Avoid working for free as a general strategy, even at this early stage. A low, honest price still creates a real commitment on both sides, which tends to produce more serious engagement than an arrangement where nothing was actually risked.

Whatever number you choose, decide it in advance and say it clearly when asked, rather than freezing or dramatically underselling yourself in the moment out of nervousness.

This first price is not permanent. It is simply the number that gets you your first real proof, which then quickly becomes the foundation for every price that follows.

Chapter 7

Handling the Awkward Money Conversation

Talking about money can feel uncomfortable, especially with someone you know personally, or with your very first client where the stakes feel unusually high.

A simple, steady tone helps far more than an apologetic one. State the price plainly, pause, and let the silence sit rather than immediately filling it with justifications or discounts.

If someone pushes back on price, it is fine to hold steady calmly, or offer a smaller version of the work at the same rate, rather than instantly lowering the number simply to avoid discomfort.

Put the agreement in writing, even briefly, a simple message confirming the price and what is included. This protects both sides and quietly signals that you are treating the work professionally from the very first project.

The discomfort around this conversation fades noticeably after the first few times. Like most things in this book, it is uncomfortable mainly because it is unfamiliar, not because it is genuinely difficult.

Chapter 8

Delivering Work That Earns the Second Client

The first client matters less for the money it brings, and far more for what it makes possible afterward, real proof, a real testimonial, and a real answer to the question, have you done this before.

Because of this, it is worth treating the first project with extra care, slightly more communication than usual, slightly more attention to small details, since the goal here extends beyond simply finishing the task.

Keep the client informed along the way, briefly, rather than disappearing until the work is finished. This small habit reassures a first time client far more than people expect, since they are taking a real risk on someone unproven too.

Deliver slightly more thoughtfully than the bare minimum required, not through overworking yourself, but through small, visible signs of care, clean presentation, a short note explaining your choices, a following up message after delivery.

A client who feels genuinely well cared for during their first experience with you becomes far more than a single payment, they become your first real advocate.

Chapter 9

Asking For a Testimonial Without Cringing

Asking for a testimonial can feel awkward, like asking someone to compliment you directly, but it is one of the most valuable things you can request after finishing your first project.

Make it easy for them by asking a specific question rather than a vague one. Instead of, could you leave a review, try, would you be willing to share a sentence or two about what it was like working together, I would love to include it on my page.

Ask soon after delivering the work, while their experience is still fresh, rather than weeks later when the details have faded and the request feels more like an imposition.

If they are hesitant or busy, offer to draft a short version based on what they told you during the project, and simply ask them to confirm or adjust it, which lowers the effort required from them considerably.

One honest sentence from a real first client carries more weight with future clients than almost anything you could say about yourself.

Chapter 10

What Changes After Client Number One

Something shifts quietly after the first client, not dramatically, but noticeably. You are no longer someone who has never been paid for this skill, you are someone who has, even if only once so far.

The second client tends to come easier than the first, partly through growing confidence, and partly because you now have one small, real piece of proof to point to that simply did not exist before.

It is worth pausing here, briefly, to notice what actually worked in landing that first client, since it usually reveals a repeatable pattern worth using again, rather than something that felt entirely like luck.

From here, the process in this book essentially repeats, find the next specific opportunity, reach out clearly, deliver with care, ask for proof, only now with slightly more evidence and considerably less fear behind each step.

The hardest client you will ever land is very often the first one. Nearly everything that follows builds more directly on top of it than people expect.

Conclusion

One Is the Hardest Number

If there is one thing worth remembering from this book, it is that going from zero clients to one is genuinely harder than going from one to ten. The loneliness and uncertainty of that first stretch is real, and it is temporary.

Pick one small, specific step from this book, perhaps creating your one proof piece, or listing five people already close enough to approach, and take it this week, rather than waiting to feel fully ready.

Thank you for reading. Whoever your first client turns out to be, may they simply be the beginning of a much longer, easier list that follows.